

Dinky Data

Flash drives, uncommon just a year ago, now find a place in any worker's pocket. If you're in the market for one, here's what you should be buying

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They're called "pen drives," "thumb drives," "data vaults," and "Flash drives"—of which the last is the technically correct name. Small and more rugged than any other popular media, they're particularly useful for people who keep transferring data between different machines. You can even carry your office with you thanks to the newer U3 drives, which allow you to use any application without installing it on a computer. What's more, you can install a Linux distro onto your Flash drive and use it off the drive itself.

Most Flash drives offer password protection, and for the paranoid, some even have biometric scanners. You can also use one as a key to lock or unlock your computer.

We classified the Flash drives based on their capacity—512 MB, 1 GB, 2 GB, and 4 GB. While there are drives ranging from 256 MB to 16 GB available in the market, the price difference between 256 MB and 512 MB is negligible, so look for nothing less than 512 MB.

512 MB Drives

We received ten 512 MB drives—two from SanDisk and one each from A-DATA, iball, intex, Kingston, Odyssey, TECH-COM, Transcend and Zion. They don't have particularly fancy features, but are useful for those who want to carry documents and pictures around with them.

